was a place of enormous innovation, invention, and opulence. Military historian Andrew de la Garza has shown that Timurid rulers like Akbar were at the heart of the ‘Timurid Renaissance’ in the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries, during which great advances were made in the arts, literature, architecture, engineering, and the sciences, far surpassing the achievements of other empires at the time.

From an early age, Akbar displayed a spirit of compassion and empathy which, combined with his courage and self-belief, allowed him to make audacious and brave decisions. He abolished the jiziya and the pilgrimage tax on non-Muslims, to the horror of conservative Muslims. He prohibited the slaughter of cows and peacocks, in deference to Hindu sentiments. He instituted patronage for Hindu and Jain temples. He ended slavery in the empire and set the example by freeing all the bandas* in his household. He tried to discourage the practice of sati, while trying not to offend Hindu sentiments, and personally rode out to prevent royal Rajput women from being forced to commit sati as soon as he heard of such instances. He set up food kitchens and inns for the poor, and tried to distribute wealth to the needy to permanently eradicate poverty. And against the tenets of both Hinduism and Islam, he tried to elevate the position of women, recognizing their essential vulnerability within both these religious systems. Aside from discouraging sati, Akbar raised the minimum marriageable age of boys and girls, advocated monogamy, and criticized the Muslim laws of inheritance that favoured boys. In the sixteenth century, and for an Islamic monarch, this remains a unique achievement.

One of the reasons that Akbar was so willing to look beyond Islam for truths and validation was that, as relatively recent converts to Islam, the Mughals were less tenacious in their allegiance to religion alone. They carried with them many other symbols of their legitimacy. They comfortably inhabited the pre-Islamic pagan practices and elements of Chenghiz (Genghis) Khan’s yassa laws as well since their ancestor,

Timur, could lay claim to a Chingizid heritage, for he had married women from that illustrious clan. It should be pointed out though that the Mughals were much more attached to their Timurid past than to their Chingizid one, striving for the perfection of Samarkand and its refined culture of elegant gardens, buildings, art, poetry, and music. In strictly Islamic states at that time, the rulers were bound by the sharia and were meant to submit to the ulema, the Muslim clerics. These clerics would have expected the clear